DataiQ™

Deliberate Decisions

How Grounded Leadership is Advancing the Path to Enterprise AI Value

In partnership with databricks



Ian Fish
Chief Executive Officer
DataIQ

Foreword

Data and AI leaders are navigating a moment that will shape their organisations for years to come. The opportunity is enormous, the scrutiny intense and the course ahead far from clear.

That is why Guild matters: it gives leaders the space to examine these decisions.

For two days each year, an exceptional group of leaders comes together to compare experience, challenge assumptions and test the judgement calls they are making in their own organisations. The trust in the room allows people to openly share what is working, where they have pushed back, and the challenges that remain unresolved.

It is a privilege for DataIQ to convene this community together with Guild's strategic partner Databricks. As their role becomes more consequential, these leaders are moving beyond enabling data and AI capability to help the enterprise make assured progress despite an ever-changing backdrop.

This report captures that collective thinking. Our hope is that it gives leaders greater clarity and confidence to make the judgement calls that now define the role.



Lexy Kassan
Data and AI Strategist
Databricks

Partner Foreword

To lead data and AI today is to navigate a constant tension between commitment and flexibility.

Every investment, architecture and operating model decision requires leaders to balance confidence in what they know today with openness to what may change tomorrow. In a landscape where technology is advancing rapidly and certainty remains elusive, success depends on knowing where to commit and where to preserve choice.

At Databricks, we believe organisations need four foundations to navigate this environment successfully: Context, Control, Cost and Choice.

Context ensures AI is grounded in trusted, governed data. Control gives leaders confidence that innovation can be pursued responsibly and securely. Cost matters because sustainable adoption requires balancing ambition with efficiency. Choice remains essential in a fast-moving market, ensuring organisations can evolve alongside new technologies, models and business priorities.

These principles underpin our approach, from the Lakebase which provides a governed transactional foundation for building and running data and AI applications and agents, to capabilities such as Genie, which ensure people and AI agents can responsibly and efficiently access organisational context.

Our partnership with DataIQ Guild reflects that same philosophy. As this report demonstrates, progress comes not from waiting for certainty, but from making informed decisions in its absence. Our commitment is to help leaders make those decisions with confidence, grounded in the realities of their organisations and with the freedom to preserve choice.

databricks

Introduction



Introduction

> *It requires honest, evidence-backed communication. Above all, it requires constant judgement calls on where to be deliberate, where to hold firm, and where to stay open to change.*

The role of the CDO has been to provide data foundations that their organisations can trust. AI deployments are increasingly surfacing where this work has yet to be done. "*It's as if we're building on water,*" was how one leader described it at this year's DataIQ Guild.

This is putting previous successes with data integration under scrutiny. That pressure is increased by corporate ambitions to deploy AI at scale. For data and AI leaders, the emerging conflict is between pace and predictability.

Critically, how can leaders keep making progress when the conditions around AI are still moving?

From the collective response at Guild emerged a style of leadership that prioritises deliberate evidence-based decisions over attempting to meet expectation. Stability combined with flexibility. Influence rather than control. Proof over hype.

It is far from simple. It requires honest, evidence-backed communication. Above all, it requires constant judgement calls on where to be deliberate, where to hold firm, and where to stay open to change.

Five leadership disciplines emerged from across Guild attendees:

1. Confidence grounded in reality

2. Enterprise choices, not demand-led reactions

3. Leadership through influence, not control

4. Human judgement as a strategic capability

5. Stability without rigidity

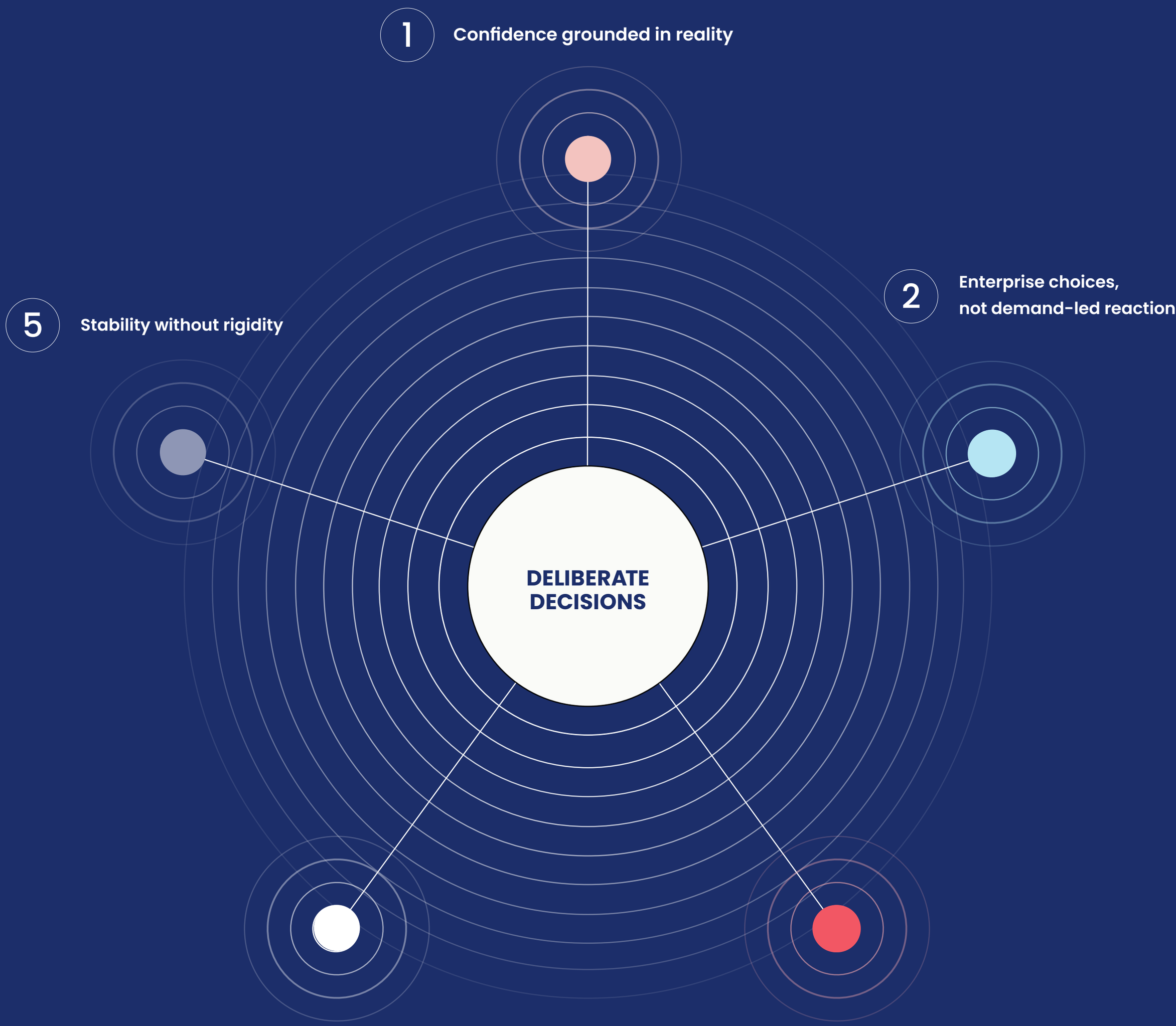
This report explores each of these disciplines and the key actions leaders are taking to keep their organisations on course.





DataIQ

The Deliberate Decisions Leadership Model



Key Leadership Pressures

Common pressures are shaping the current data and AI environment. A new set of leadership behaviours among data and AI leaders is emerging.

Early success, inflated expectations

Early AI results are raising expectations that the enterprise is ready to progress quickly and real ROI is within reach.

→ **Leaders need to recalibrate confidence and ground it in evidence.**

More experimentation than the organisation can absorb

Ideas, pilots and proofs of concept are multiplying faster than organisations can assess, fund, govern and support them.

→ **Leaders must prioritise work with enterprise-scale potential over local enthusiasm.**

Shared responsibility, unclear ownership

AI adoption and delivery spans departments, so decisions and consequences, costs and risks need clear business owners.

→ **Leaders must ensure that cross-functional collaboration strengthens accountability.**

Work changing faster than roles can settle

AI adoption is outpacing role definitions, workflow settings and decision boundaries. Organisations have yet to determine the extent of the “human reserve”.

→ **Leaders must support adaptation and critical thinking to avoid cognitive off-loading to AI.**

Uneven readiness across the enterprise

Data foundations, skills, sponsorship and the capacity to adopt AI are operating at different speeds across organisations.

→ **Leaders must maintain a shared direction across different starting points.**

Five Leadership Disciplines for Deliberate Decisions



DataIQ

1 Confidence Grounded in Reality

Enthusiasm for AI matters. But it needs to be grounded in evidence about genuine progress, tempered with reality checks on what remains unproven or uncertain.

AI adoption is not the same as AI readiness. Productivity tools do not equate with agentic AI. The roll-out never delivers at the same scale as the pilot.

These are truths that leaders must be willing to voice, challenging assumptions that the business may make based on limited evidence.

Grounded confidence supports sustainable pace, rather than acting as a brake on progress.

Maturity is what survives production

Production is where a different test begins. The question is no longer simply whether an AI capability works, but whether it can remain useful, reliable and affordable as it encounters the realities of the live enterprise.

A pilot proves that a capability can work under bounded conditions. Production tests whether the organisation can sustain it. Once AI enters a live workflow, the surrounding requirements become visible: models and prompts change, user behaviour evolves, support and monitoring are needed, governance becomes continuous, and costs extend well beyond the technology itself.



> *"The cost is not just the model or the tool. It is the security, the support, the adoption, the governance and the operating model around it. If those costs are invisible, the business case is incomplete."*
> **Thomas Gebetsroither, Data & Analytics Operations Lead, Axpo Trading & Sales**

This is where early success can create false confidence. A working pilot may look like evidence of enterprise readiness, but operational maturity depends on whether the organisation can support, govern, adopt and afford the capability over time.

Foundations reveal themselves under pressure

A successful pilot can conceal weaknesses in the foundations beneath it. Data can appear dependable while it remains inside familiar reports, systems and processes. The harder test comes when it is asked to do something new: move between platforms, support a different business purpose, feed an AI model or agent, or operate repeatedly at greater scale.

Leaders must treat new uses of data as a readiness test in their own right and identify where foundations can bear weight and where further reinforcement is needed before AI scales.

AI telemetry is becoming enterprise data

AI systems generate a new layer of organisational evidence: prompts, traces, token usage, outputs, corrections, failures, human interventions, agent actions, workflow loops and cost signals.

These signals show how AI is actually being used, where humans intervene, where workflows break down and where documented processes diverge from real behaviour.

Leaders are incorporating it into their data strategies, using it to evaluate and improve AI systems, and to understand how work is changing, where friction sits and which processes may need to be redesigned.

Leaders must treat new uses of data as a readiness test in their own right and identify where foundations can bear weight and where further reinforcement is needed before AI scales.



2 Enterprise Choices, Not Demand-Led Reactions

Demand is created top down via the board setting priorities and bottom up from business functions transforming processes. It also arrives internally from colleagues deploying tools they have been provided with and externally from vendor push.

But demand cannot determine the agenda for AI development – business leaders must. This involves striking a balance between enterprise goals and function needs, the expected value and the scale of change involved.

For data and AI leaders, this means helping to improve the quality of those decisions: making trade-offs visible, challenging use cases, and sometimes pushing back. Most find that a well-founded "no" or "not yet" builds credibility when the reasoning is clear.

Start with a well-defined business problem

AI development is often the answer to a business problem which has not been asked or not clearly defined. Leaders are clear that good definitions lead to better outcomes. And sometimes that might not involve AI – it could be a simpler approach or even one involving no tech at all.



> *"The most important collaboration happens before design and delivery starts. With the business, we test the five whys, surface dependencies and impacts and agree what measurable value the initiative is designed create."*
> **Abbi Agana, CEO, Leathermarket JMB**

Trade-offs are business decisions

Prioritisation regularly falls to the data and AI leader, but enterprise priorities ultimately need to be owned by the business.



> *"Prioritisation belongs with the business, not the data office. My role is to make the trade-offs clear by asking: if we move ahead with this, what do we stop doing?"*
> **Chris Gullick, Chief Data and AI Officer, Ofgem**

ExCo owns the outcome

AI investment decisions are increasingly escalated to the executive committee. Sponsors must explain why the use case matters, expected ROI or productivity gains, and alignment to the organisation's strategic goals.



> *"We want the business to be accountable. Any of the use cases that we get prioritised need to have an impact on the long-range plan."*
> **Bharathi Rajan, VP – Data, Digital & AI, Swire Coca-Cola**

Capture enterprise-level value

The real benefits of AI emerge from transformed process and ways of working, not point solutions that may just move work downstream.



> *"Individual productivity is not the same as enterprise value."*
> **David Castro-Gavino, Executive Director, Axial - Head of Data Deployment, AstraZeneca**

Leaders need to ask what changes end-to-end:

- Does work disappear, or merely move?
- Is decision velocity faster?
- Have outcomes improved?
- Has AI reduced risk?
- Is capacity released or a reusable solution created?
- Can we capture the full value when operating at scale?

Manage AI value as a portfolio

AI investment is often assessed use case by use case, with each carrying ROI expectations. Leaders consider that a venture-capital portfolio management approach may be better: make a range of initial bets, increase investment as evidence strengthens and stop or redirect those that fail to justify further commitment.



> *"Not every investment needs to pay back in the same way. Some will deliver direct value, some will generate learning and some will create capabilities that can be reused across the organisation."*
> **Gavin Goodland, Chief Data Officer, National Grid**

3 Lead Through Influence, Not Control

AI typically crosses organisational boundaries. Often, initial demands land on the data and AI leader. As AI moves closer to the point of action, this pulls leadership closer to business outcomes.

But the levers that determine those outcomes remain distributed. Adoption, workflow change, risk, operational support and benefits realisation sit across the enterprise.

Leaders therefore need to create clarity and commitment across areas they can influence but do not directly control.

Standards, decision rights and governance are structures that give the business confidence to maintain momentum without taking ownership. Influence works best when the business understands both the freedom it has and the safeguards around AI.

Responsible AI as an easy enabler

Centralised decisions are not always possible as AI scales. Instead, leaders aim to influence pathways that allow users to adopt it responsibly.

This means proportionate governance: lighter routes for low-risk experimentation, stronger controls where sensitive data, regulated activity or operational decisions are involved, and early security input before work becomes difficult to unwind.







“We need to give teams room to experiment safely, while using those early use cases to identify and implement the guardrails required for scale.”
Ryan Moore, Director of Data, The Guardian

Contribution to the shared capability

As AI activity expands across the enterprise, leaders need to define the conditions under which work progresses.



“While giving teams the freedom to innovate is essential for speed, new AI and analytics initiatives must contribute to the organisation’s broader data-product ecosystem rather than creating isolated assets that serve only local needs.”
Frédéric Bernard-Payen, Data Governance Senior Expert, Airbus

Ownership over flex

Many business functions want to deploy AI and own the upsides. Fewer are prepared to own in full the outcomes, including supporting adoption programmes, mitigating operational consequences and funding ongoing costs.

Clear decision rights are part of the picture. But approval of an AI use case without taking ownership of the consequences is a red flag. Leaders need to pause until there is enough commitment around the outcome for the work to have somewhere to land.



“If there is a business owner prepared to own the outcome, we can move forward. Without that ownership, we stop.”
Chris Gullick, Chief Data & AI Officer, Ofgem





4 Human Judgement as a Strategic Capability

AI is changing the balance between what humans and machines contribute in the workplace.

As systems take on more execution, people spend less time producing outputs and more time framing problems, interpreting results and deciding on the next action.

DataIQ describes this emerging blended human-AI workforce as Generation T (for Terminator).

Leaders increasingly recognise three implications of this that are easy to underestimate:

- Employees become confident AI users before they develop the judgement to challenge what it produces.
- Human review can remain part of a process on paper while becoming difficult to exercise at AI speed and volume.
- Automating routine work removes the opportunity to build experience through which professional judgement gets developed.

Human judgement is not just the part of work left over after automation – it is part of an organisation's intellectual capital and IP. It also creates value that is easier to lose than to quantify.

Human relationships carry context, trust and institutional knowledge across an organisation; they surface weak signals, connect problems to people who know how to solve them; and create the conditions in which challenge happens early.

Whatever AI's potential, how it will perform within – or indeed transform – complex organisations is as yet unknown. The challenge for leaders is not to protect people from automation. It is to avoid automating away capabilities the organisation cannot replace.

> *The challenge for leaders is not to protect people from automation. It is to avoid automating away capabilities the organisation cannot replace.*

Make human authority clear

AI at scale makes "human-in-the-loop" hard to sustain. People may technically remain reviewers but have too little time or context to challenge each output meaningfully. Or they simply become overwhelmed.

Human authority therefore needs to be more explicit than a review step. Leaders need to decide which decisions remain human-owned, where people have the authority to override or stop a system, and how that authority can still be exercised once AI is embedded in the workflow.



"We use AI in line with our principles, but we preserve human judgement over the outputs that define who we are."
Ryan Moore, Director of Data, The Guardian

Build the right skills for the role

AI capability needs to match responsibility. The greater someone's influence over AI design, access, deployment or outcomes, the greater the level of understanding they need.

Business owners and senior leaders need enough fluency to challenge claims, understand trade-offs and make sound decisions about where AI should and should not be used.

The goal is role-appropriate fluency: enough understanding to use, build, govern or make decisions about AI well.



"We embedded AI learning into our ExCo and gave them tools so they can learn and experiment for themselves. The objective was not to turn our ExCo into AI experts but to enable them to role model, challenge providers, test assumptions and ask the right questions."
Tom Spencer, Director of Customer Data Sciences, Aviva

Build pathways to competence

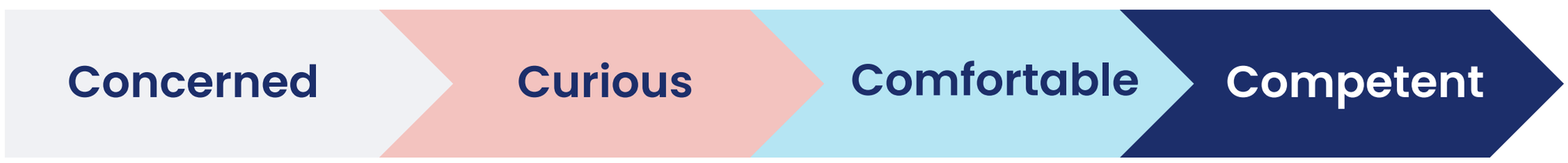
Attitudes to AI differ greatly across the organisation from fear and scepticism to overconfidence in abilities. Each impacts the progress of adoption and requires different approaches to guide employees towards competent use in their role.



"There are four stages to the adoption journey: concerned, curious, comfortable and competent. Once people reach competence, they then become the change agents who help the wider organisation move forward."
Amit Pandey, Chief Data Officer, Barclays UK



AI Competency Framework



Give employees a stake in the change

AI is changing more than individual tasks. It can alter workflows, responsibilities and the way work is organised.

Yet employees often encounter those changes only once a new capability has been rolled out, creating resistance and slowing adoption.

That resistance can deepen if AI is experienced mainly as something that removes work, control or opportunity.

Giving people a role in how AI is introduced can help shift the conversation towards where they can add value, build capability and influence how work changes.



> *"The challenge is to move the workforce from scarcity thinking to growth thinking. That means giving people agency in how AI reshapes their roles, rather than asking them to simply absorb change."*
> **Lexy Kassan, Data and AI Strategist, Databricks**

Protecting expertise

Professional judgement builds through work – often the same tasks that AI is taking over. This creates a risk of losing the ability of the workforce to assess quality, spot exceptions and outliers and make effective decisions.

Recognising which aspects of work help to build this expert workforce is yet another aspect of leading AI programmes.



> *"We should not optimise for automation purely on cost. There is a point at which efficiency gains start to come at the expense of organisational knowledge and judgement."*
> **Manca Vitorino, Director of Data Ecosystem, LexisNexis Risk Solutions**

5 | Stability Without Rigidity

AI capability is developing too quickly for leaders to assume that today's operating model, structures or technology choices will remain right for long. At the same time, the enterprise needs enough continuity to project forwards. People need to know where accountability sits, which principles apply and what they can rely on as capability develops.

The task is not to try and make everything stable but to build stability deliberately where the organisation needs it. Purpose, decision rights, standards, human authority and business ownership provide continuity; roles, structures and technology choices need more room to evolve.

This builds a centre of gravity to keep the organisation on course combined with the ability to apply course corrections in response to changing macro factors.

Fixed points, flexible response

AI development and transformation is not slowing any time soon. Yet certain anchor points for deliberate decisions can be identified:

- How AI supports the business strategy and purpose.
- Where key decision rights sit.
- Which standards and boundaries apply across the enterprise.
- Where human authority must remain explicit as AI takes on more work.
- Who in the business owns the outcome once AI moves into use.



"You do not need to have all the answers. Look for progress over perfection. Momentum is important."
Samir Patel, Head of Data, BAE Systems

> *Judge new structures and roles by whether they make the organisation easier to navigate. The test is whether people can act with less friction.*

Remove friction before creating roles

Leaders should add enough structure to make the organisation easier to work with, while keeping roles and hand-offs open to review as capability and business ownership develop.

Judge new structures and roles by whether they make the organisation easier to navigate. Product managers, AI consultants, automation leads and domain roles can be valuable when they help the business frame a problem, understand its options, judge value and find a safe route to delivery.

The test is whether people can act with less friction: does the business know where to take a problem? Are decisions easier to reach? Do new roles reduce rather than create hand-offs between the problem, the solution and the business outcome.

Make reversible choices

Many leaders are making technology choices they already expect to revisit. Build versus buy. Models versus providers. Orchestration and costs.

This goes beyond concerns about vendor lock-in. If AI telemetry evidence matters, will it remain accessible if the organisation migrates away from that provider? What options are retained in a new environment to migrate critical data? How reversible is dependency within a process on a specific model?

Permanence is unlikely, therefore choices focus more on where core capabilities need to sit in the near-term without creating a dependency that cannot be reversed.



Conclusion



Conclusion

AI leadership now demands a difficult combination: enough conviction to keep moving and enough humility to accept that some of today's answers will not last.

Leaders are not waiting for a settled operating model, a perfect value framework or complete certainty about where AI will take the organisation. They are working on what is effective now – alignment to business purpose, outcome ownership, decision boundaries, human judgement, AI telemetry. All while leaving room for flexibility and review.

This requires a trade-off – preserving room to manoeuvre feels less tidy and efficient than committing hard to a single answer. Challenging demand feels slower. Keeping humans meaningfully involved is complicated. Decisions that optimise too aggressively for today can leave the organisation with less freedom tomorrow.

The leadership task is therefore not to predict the future correctly but to make progress without losing the ability to respond when the future turns out differently.

> *Enterprise value remains the critical goal. The more immediate responsibility is to build an organisation capable of reaching it; grounded enough to know what is working, disciplined enough to make choices and adaptable enough to change course when it needs to.*

Enterprise value remains the critical goal. The more immediate responsibility is to build an organisation capable of reaching it; grounded enough to know what is working, disciplined enough to make choices and adaptable enough to change course when it needs to.

The future may remain unsettled. Grounded leadership means the organisation does not have to be.





About DataIQ Guild

This report is based on discussions held at DataIQ Guild 2026. DataIQ Guild is the industry's premier invite-only think tank for senior data and AI leaders. It brings cross-industry peers together to examine the leadership questions that are difficult to resolve inside any one organisation.

Over two days, a blend of practitioner presentations, fireside and panel discussions, small-group peer exchanges and roundtables, combined with networking and after-hours socialising, delivers critical insight and value to leaders.

DataIQ Guild's strategic partner is Databricks, a collaboration that brings highly pertinent insights and unique perspectives on technology and strategic approaches.

Contributors to this report:

Abbi Agana
Chief Executive Officer
Leathermarket JMB

Frédéric Bernard-Payen
Data Governance Senior Expert
Airbus

David Castro-Gavino
Executive Director, Axial - Head of Data Deployment
AstraZeneca

Thomas Gebetsroither
Data & Analytics Operations Lead
Axpo Trading & Sales

Gavin Goodland
Chief Data Officer
National Grid

Chris Gullick
Chief Data and AI Officer
Ofgem

Lexy Kassan
Data and AI Strategist
Databricks

Ryan Moore
Director of Data
The Guardian

Amit Pandey
Chief Data Officer
Barclays UK

Samir Patel
Head of Data
BAE Systems

Bharathi Rajan
VP – Data, Digital & AI
Swire Coca-Cola

Tom Spencer
Director of Customer Data Sciences
Aviva

Manca Vitorino
Director of Data Ecosystem
LexisNexis Risk Solutions









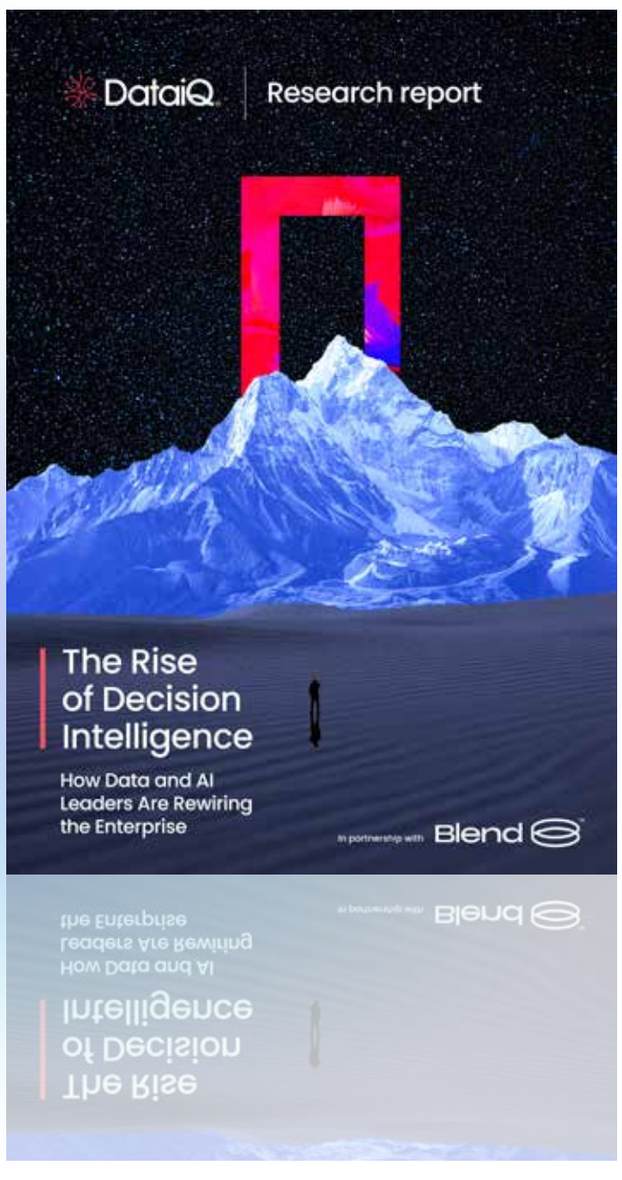






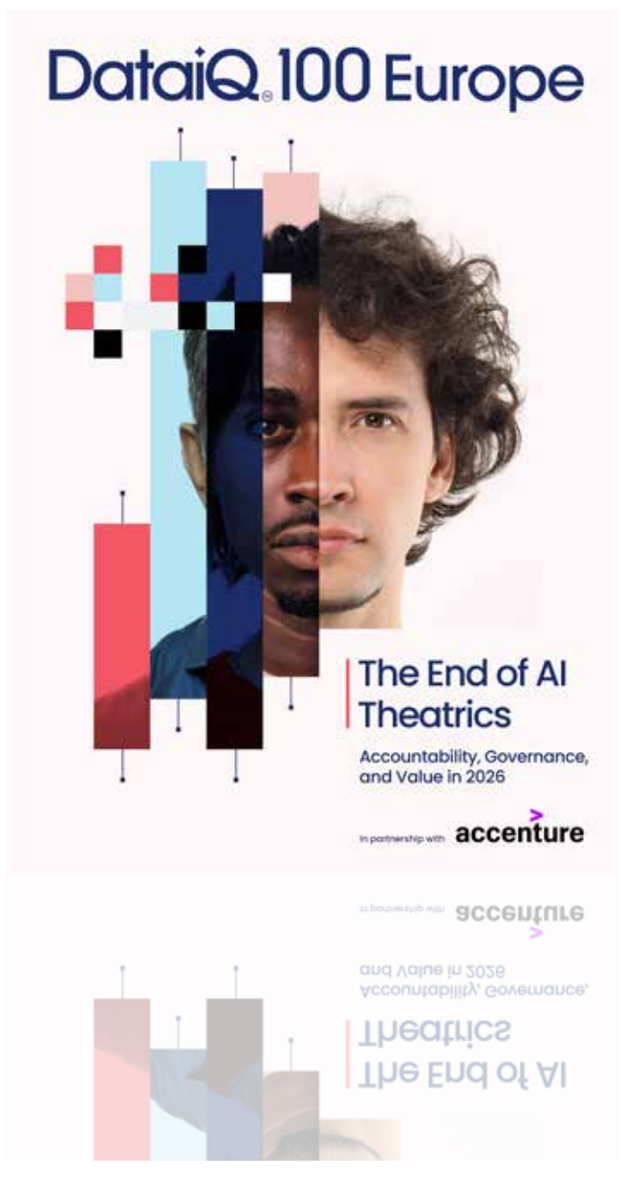


Discover more DataIQ Leadership Reports



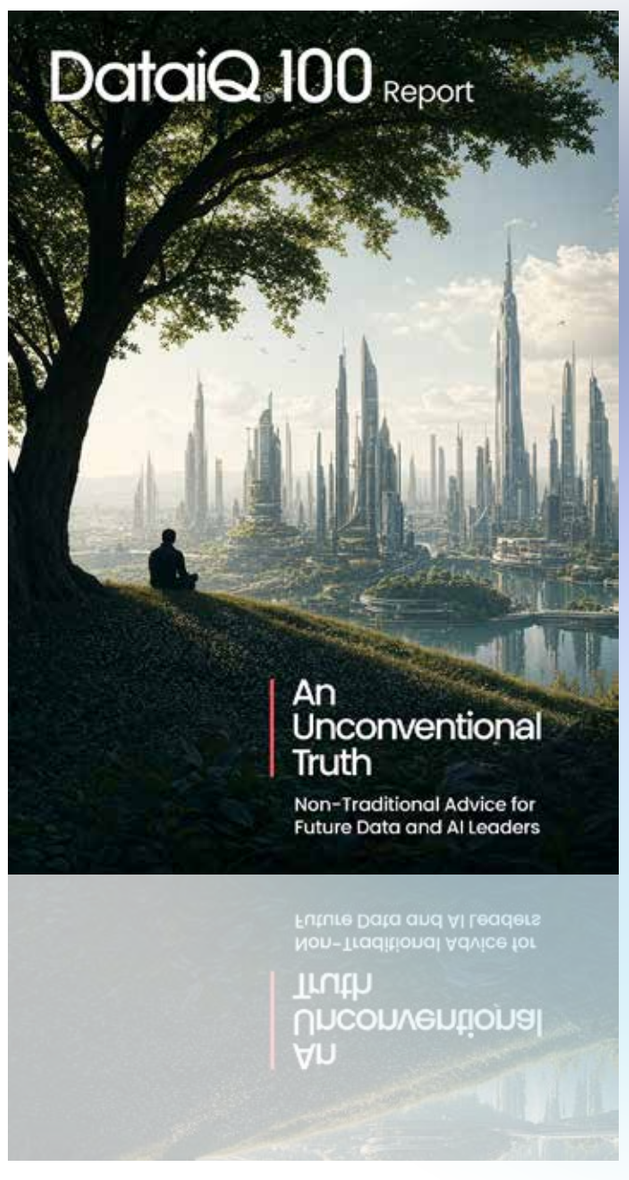
The Rise of Decision Intelligence

Download now →



The End of AI Theatrics

Download now →



An Unconventional Truth

Download now →

DataiQ

Download now at dataiq.global/articles-and-reports

“You have an **instant network** of industry experts around you.”

Sarah Barr Miller
Director of Data and AI
British Airways



Get the insights, connections, and expertise to drive impact

DataiQ™

Connect | Accelerate | Transform

dataiq.global/solutions